run kitchens in hospitals, JEEViKA has filled this gap besides providing a source of livelihood to these women—most of whom are earning for the first time. "While the hospitals provide space," adds Kumar, "we provide infrastructure and other assistance to start the business by handing over fully-equipped kitchens and canteens to the all-women groups.

The same model has been replicated across the state. Currently, 117 such women-owned enterprises are functional in all 38 districts of Bihar, serving food in government hospitals, schools, banks and other institutions. Started in 2018, the project involves over 1,700 women, who are supported by consultants experienced in hotel management and catering.

At the 180-bed BIMHAS, working in two shifts, the group of 25 women are doing their bit for the emotional wellbeing of the patients and their attendants. "No one feels good about getting admitted to hospital," says Kavita Devi, 32, the leader of this group, "and patients don't choose a hospital for its cuisine." But when the cured patients and their attendants visit the canteen to wish the 'didis' goodbye and enjoy one last meal before getting discharged, it's a sign for Kavita that her team is making a difference.

A resident of the neighbouring Kulharia village, Kavita starts her day long before sunrise. A mother of two, she first prepares breakfast and lunch for her 10-year-old son Dipansh and nine-year-old daughter Arohi, who, she says proudly, are attending an English-medium school. "I pay their fee, Rs 2,000 every month, from my own earnings," adds Kavita, whose husband works in a factory. By 6 am, she is at BIMHAS for her eight-hour shift. After a hectic day at work, she is back home post 2 pm, before her children return from school.

Even as Kavita makes Rs 6,000 a month, her earnings will be much bigger. Her group's turnover has crossed Rs 1 crore. Before this fiscal ends, the profit and accrued bank interest will be distributed equally among the 25 women. Kavita expects the profit to be at least 30 per cent of the turnover. A well-deserved bonus awaits. ■

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HAPPINESS QUOTIENT

Launched in 2018, the project has provided means of livelihood to over 1,700 women, most of whom are earning for the first time

Currently, 117 such women-owned enterprises are functional in all 38 districts of Bihar, with Rs 57.4 crore turnover so far

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ALL FIRED UP
Women running a Didi Ki Rasoi at Bihar Institute of Mental Health and Allied Sciences in Koilwar

"While hospitals give space, we provide fully-equipped kitchens and other assistance to the all-women groups"

Rahul Kumar, *Chief Executive Officer, JEEViKA*